1769–1832

Regarded as the founder of paleontology, French zoologist and naturalist Georges Cuvier made huge advances in natural science during the late 18th and early 19th centuries. He established comparative anatomy as a scientific discipline and provided conclusive proof that animal species could become extinct.

MILESTONES

PROVES EXTINCTIONS
By comparing the bones of elephants with mammoths in 1796, he proves that extinctions occur.

AGE OF THE EARTH
In 1804, observes that the Earth must be far older than previously believed due to the age of fossils.

GROUPS ORGANISMS
Publishes his system of classifying organisms in 1817 and advances the field of animal taxonomy.

EARTH'S STRUCTURE
Proposes a theory in 1825 that past natural disasters affected the Earth's geological structure.

Georges Cuvier was born in Montbéliard, a town on the French-Swiss border which was then part of the German duchy of Württemberg, now in France. Educated at the prestigious Caroline Academy in Stüttgart, he studied comparative anatomy, a relatively new science examining similarities and differences between animal species. After writing detailed original studies of marine invertebrates, in 1795, Cuvier was offered a job at the National Museum of National History, Paris. There, he carried out the research that would establish him as one of the most influential figures of 19th-century natural sciences.

Theory of extinction

Using the museum's collection of animal specimens, Cuvier furthered his studies in comparative anatomy—in particular, by comparing the remains of living animals with fossils. The results he discovered were revelatory. Until the late 18th century, scientists had believed that fossils were the remains of extant (living) species, and that no animal species had ever

__Many of Cuvier's publications__ were based on lectures he gave in Paris. In these, he captivated audiences with reconstructed skeletons of animals that no longer walked the Earth.